

M I C R O S O F T 2 0 2 6 P A N E L

Microsoft Certifications in 2026

What Actually Matters

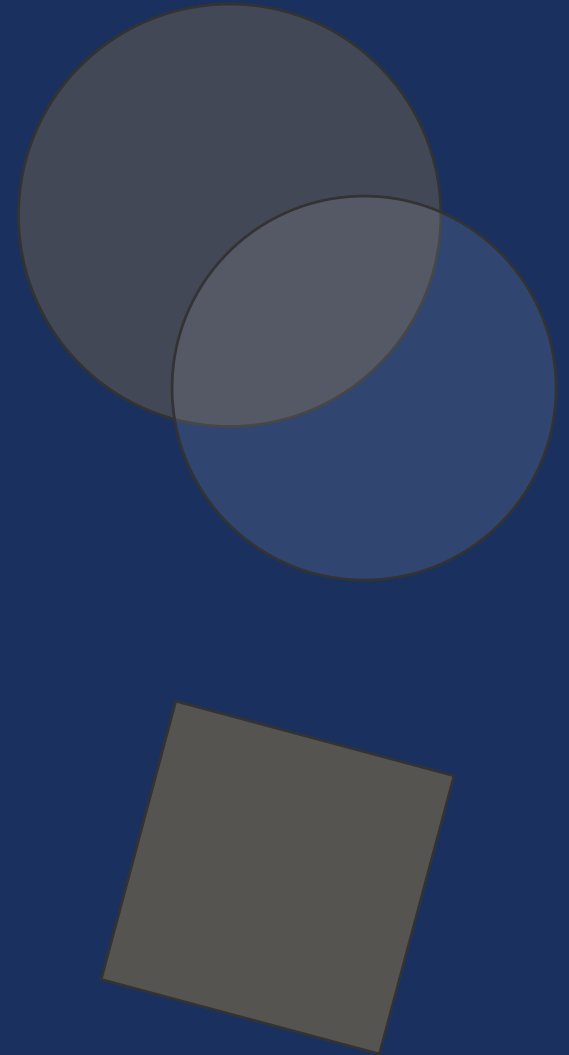
ALEXANDR ABDULCA

Senior Microsoft 365 & Power Platform Developer

21

Microsoft Certifications
earned in 3 years

M A Y 2 0 2 6



Why listen to me?

A practitioner's view — earned by building, not just by passing.



21

MICROSOFT CERTIFICATIONS

Across M365, Azure, AI, Power
Platform, Security, and Data.



REAL

WORLD BUILDER

Production solutions across the
Microsoft stack — not just exam
theory.



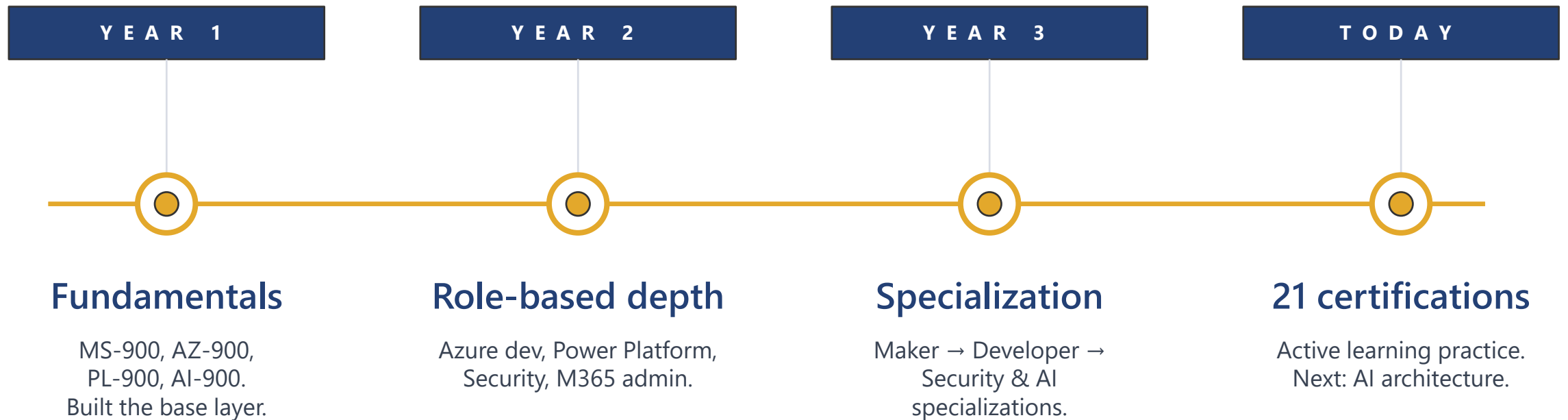
REAL

WORLD PERSPECTIVE

What certs actually do for your career
— and what they don't.

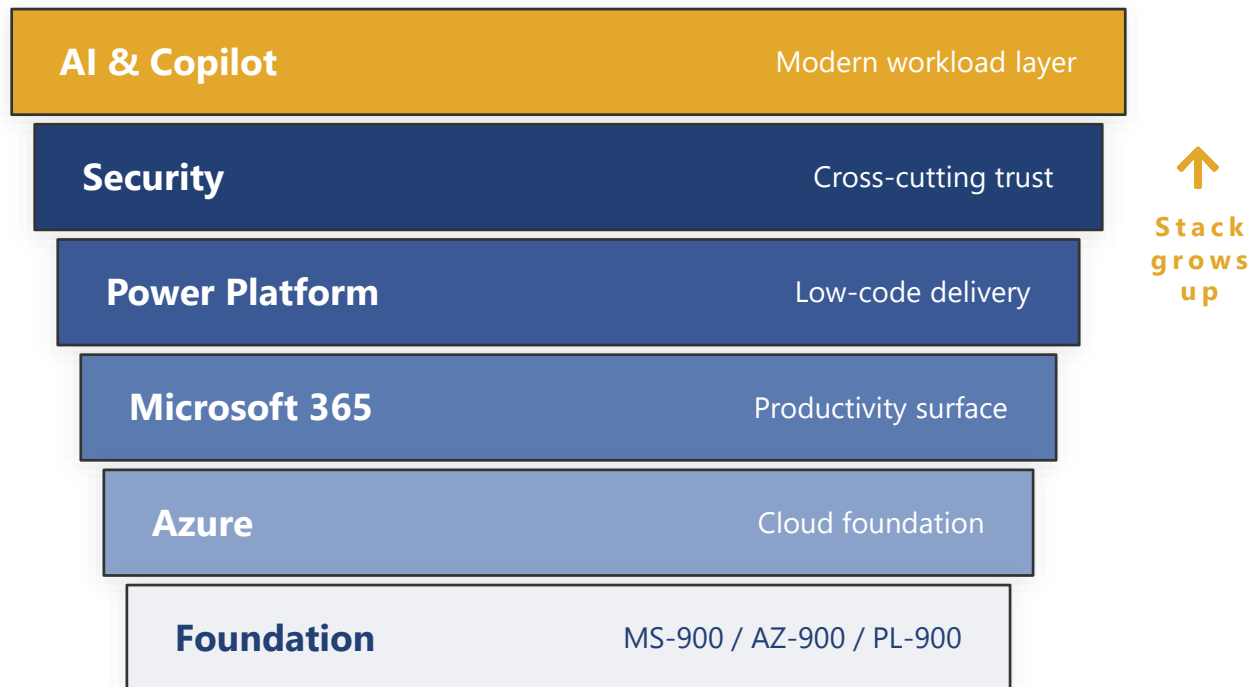
My journey

Consistency beats intensity. Layers, not sprints.



My certification strategy

I didn't collect badges. I stacked layers that compound.



01

Layer, don't scatter

Each cert builds on the last. Azure unlocks Power Platform unlocks AI.

02

Direction over speed

Pick the next cert that compounds with what you already do at work.

03

Practice in between

Apply the skill before moving on. Otherwise it doesn't stick.

04

Hot edges, cool core

Refresh the foundation, then chase the new things (AI, Copilot, agents).

My certification portfolio

Grouped by discipline — built to reinforce each other.



STRONGEST

Power Platform

5 certifications

PL-900

PL-100

PL-200

PL-300

PL-400

★ ANCHOR



3

Microsoft 365

MS-700 · MS-102 · MS-900



3

Azure

AZ-900 · AZ-204 · AZ-500



4

Security

SC-200 · SC-300 · SC-400 · SC-401



2

AI

AI-900 · AI-102



3

Data & Dynamics

DP-900 · MB-910 · MB-920

What is a certification?

Useful — but only if you know what it is and what it isn't.

01



Verified proof

Microsoft-backed validation that you've covered a structured body of knowledge.

02



Career signal

Helps with credibility, growth, and giving direction to what you study next.

03



Not a substitute

It's not a replacement for real experience. Building still matters more.

Do you actually need one?

Certifications help — they aren't mandatory for everyone.



YOU PROBABLY SHOULD

- ✓ You're early in your career and need a credibility signal
- ✓ You're switching tracks (admin → developer, dev → AI)
- ✓ Your employer pays for it or rewards it
- ✓ You learn better with a syllabus and a deadline
- ✓ You want to enter the Microsoft Partner ecosystem



MAYBE YOU DON'T

- ⊖ You have a strong portfolio that already speaks for itself
- ⊖ Your role doesn't reward credentials — it rewards shipped work
- ⊖ You're chasing badges to avoid actually building
- ⊖ The exam doesn't map to anything you'll do this year
- ⊖ You'd learn more by writing the project than studying for it

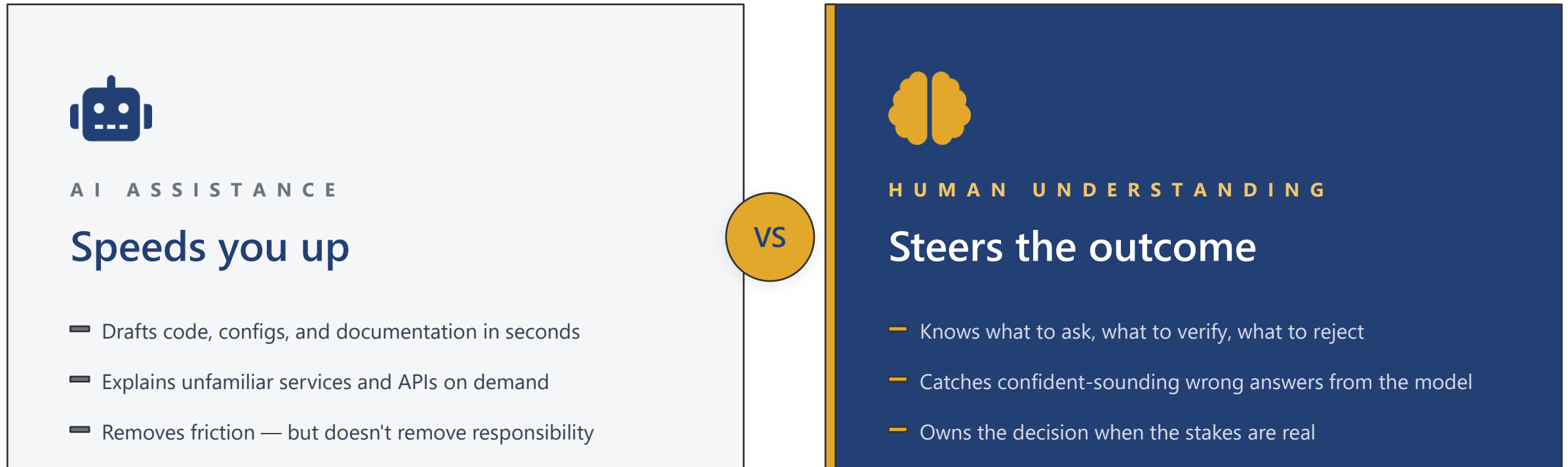
The market is changing

Certifications are being reshaped — by AI, by Copilot, and by what the industry actually verifies.



AI changed what a certification proves

Speed got cheap. Judgment got expensive.



A certification today proves **learning discipline and judgment** — the two things AI can't shortcut for you.

HOT
TAKE

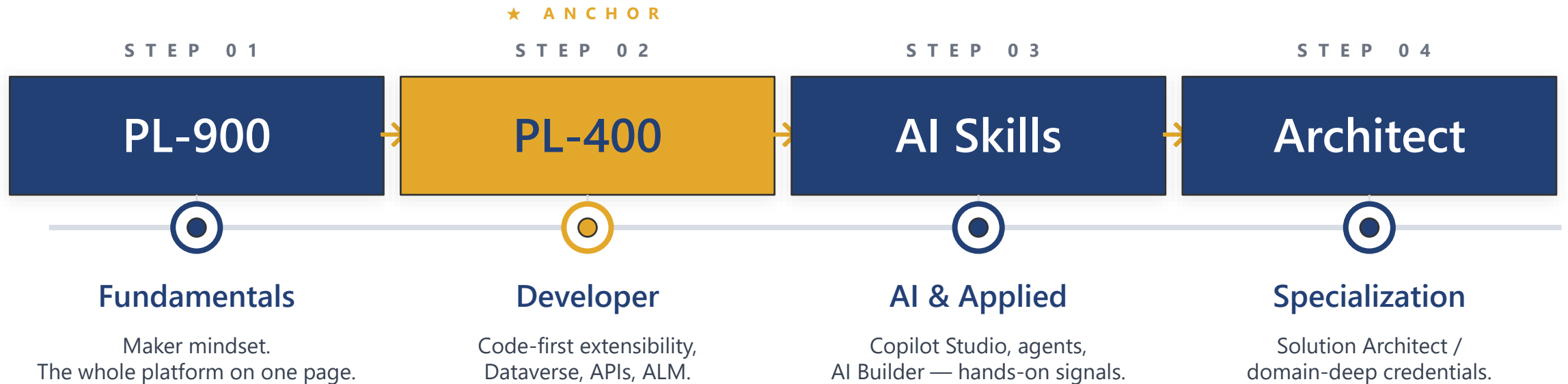


Certifications don't prove
you're good.

But they prove you take *growth* seriously.

A clean path through Power Platform

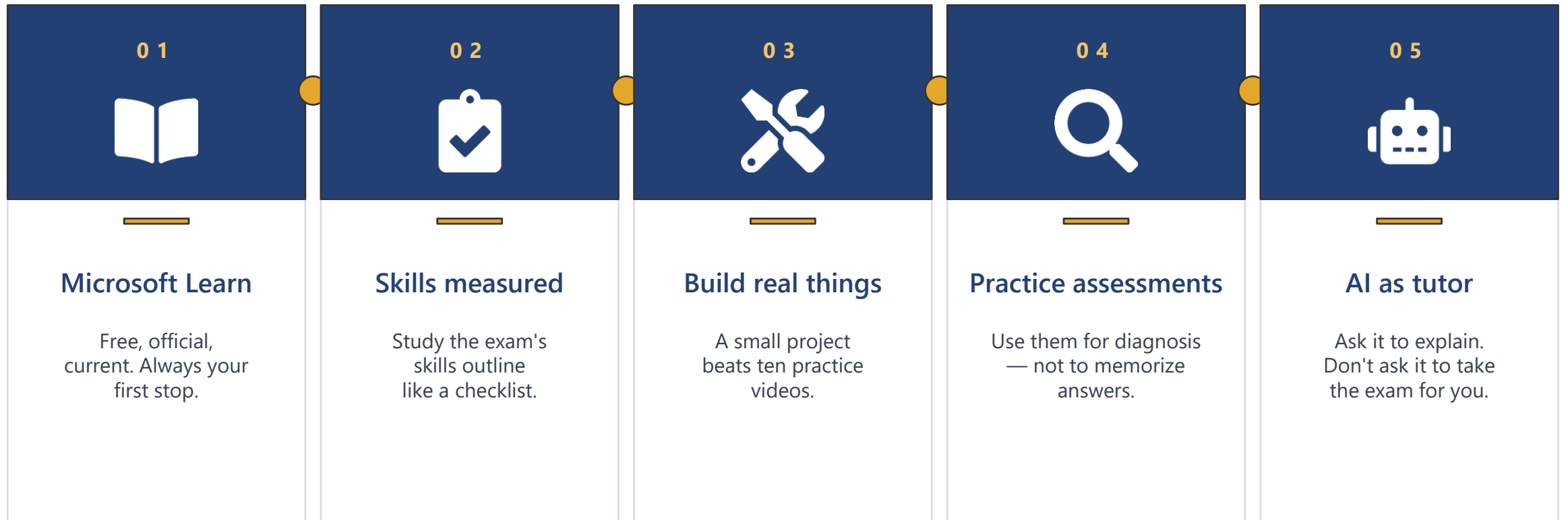
Each step opens the door to the next. Skip steps and you'll feel the gap later.



Layer security and AI on top — that's where **Power Platform careers compound in 2026.**

How to actually prepare

Five habits that work — in this order.



How to use AI for exam prep

AI is a great study partner. It's a terrible substitute teacher.

✓ DO · GOOD USES

- ✓ Explain a concept in plain language, then test you on it
- ✓ Generate practice questions from the skills outline
- ✓ Compare two services or features side by side
- ✓ Walk through a scenario and ask Socratic follow-ups
- ✓ Translate documentation into examples you'd actually build

✗ DON'T · BAD USES

- ✗ Memorize raw answer dumps it generates for you
- ✗ Trust confident-sounding output without verifying
- ✗ Skip the docs because the chatbot summarized them
- ✗ Outsource thinking — then act surprised on exam day
- ✗ Use it to bypass the parts that are actually the learning

D O N ' T P A Y F U L L P R I C E

How to get certification deals

Free vouchers and discounts are out there — if you know where to look.



Microsoft Build

Free vouchers via sessions, labs, and challenges.



Microsoft Ignite

Cloud Skills Challenge unlocks free exam vouchers.



AI Skills Challenge

Periodic global campaigns — finish and qualify.



Microsoft Learn

Cloud Skills Challenges throughout the year.



Partner / Employer

Microsoft Partners and employers often fund exams.



Community Promos

MVPs, user groups, and meetups share codes.



T R A C K T H E D E A L S

msfthub.com

/vouchers

Aggregates active vouchers,
challenges, and partner offers.

Mistakes I made

So you don't have to repeat them.

01

Studied passively

Watched videos and read pages. Didn't retain it because I never used it.



02

Skipped hands-on builds

Took exams before I'd touched the product in anger. The first real project hurt.



03

Overthought the exams

Burned weeks on edge cases that never showed up. Cover the basics deeply, then move on.



04

Underrated consistency

An hour a day beats a weekend cram. The streak is the strategy.



What to do after you pass

Passing is the start. These four moves convert a badge into a career step.

MOVE 01

01



Apply it this week

Use the skill on something real before it fades. Forty-eight hours is the window.

MOVE 02

02



Share it publicly

Post on LinkedIn. The signal compounds — recruiters and peers notice.

MOVE 03

03



Build a project

Ship one thing that demonstrates the cert. That's your portfolio piece.

MOVE 04

04



Pick the next intentionally

Choose what compounds with your role and your direction — not what's trending.

FINAL
TAKEAWAY

Certifications still
matter — but only when
paired with ***real practice.***

Thank you.

ALEX ABDULCA · SENIOR MICROSOFT 365 & POWER PLATFORM DEVELOPER

21 certifications · 3 years · still learning